

TLLOA

THE PATH



PROLOGUE

...

The path is. As far back as I can
remember, it was. It will be.
My memory is useless. What is
left is to keep moving.

Rain. A broken fence. Drenched
to the bone, mud on my bare feet.

The orchard.

It had long surrendered to rot.
The house was worse: roof gone,
one wall collapsed, ivy claiming
what was left.

A figure in front.

Travelers and the Ones That
Lost die without a sound.
I never buried any of them.

Rain gathered on its shoulders
and ran from its sleeves. The air
heavy, pressing down.

Twilight rode the path. Neither
of us moved.

...

The tea is cold and tasteless.

I banished them.

Every night they knock on the door. Every day the sharp winds batter my bones. I climb to the only surviving turret.

I observe.

Another sip.

I rest my trembling hands on the great lens overlooking the path. It continues, oblivious to its audience.

...

I had to move, but my resolve was broken. Something bore into my mind.

Patient.

Buried.

Fear.

Every direction a mistake. The
failure, unacceptable.

The figure stood in the ruins,
taking root in my emptiness.

I was still.

Static.

...

The knocking.

Unstoppable.

Its echoes torment the walls
around me. The wooden stairs
leading to the turret squeak
under every step.

My eyes twitch. I have to clean
the great lens—the birds had
soiled it again. I polish the glass
with my dirty sleeve.

A sip.

...

The path demands sacrifice.
The figure obeys—it breaks my
resolve.

I let go.

A corpse driven by the current,
dragged down a cold river.

No turning back. No direction.

I've let the water carry my
remains. The current gave up its
burden.

I washed up on another shore.

...

Through the glass, I see him
on the path. The razor wind
begins its work — clothes, skin,
whatever's left.

Tea?

Failure.
The loop.
Static.

ASCENT

...

I woke to waves touching my feet. Water and sand, both black. It was hard to tell where tide ended and the shore began.

Buried and aching, I tried to stand.

The path is one. Its variations many.

Behind the beach lay a steep hill, strewn with sparse vegetation, climbing to meet the gray sky.

Barefoot, I climbed, every root and stone a small argument against it.

...

There was a time without the sound of knocking.

The lower part of the mansion is never quiet these days. But these days are the only ones I have.

Yesterday is also the day after tomorrow, which is today.

And today, the knocking is
unbearable.

The wind takes my tea cup off
the turret wall.
I am forced to venture outside.

...
The climb continued.
The limp got worse.

My feet dragged on, leaving
pieces of myself on the stone.

The hill was slowly turning into
a mountain. I woke up with the
taste of blood in my mouth.

The stones. Pain.
The trees that were not here
anymore.

I had to climb. When I managed
to stand, it was hard to breathe.

There should have been clouds
here.
There weren't.

A decision.

A pebble, loose underfoot, rolled
toward the edge.

Then I left the path.

...

There is no one outside. The
knocking has stopped. The wind
is relentless.

I reach for the tea cup. Beside it
lies a white pebble. One more for
the collection.

Time to climb the stairs again.

The lens, still there, unbothered
by birds and wind.

The traveler strays.
The path remembers.
Movement.

INVERSION

...

There's blood on my knuckles.
Blood on the door.
There is no answer.

I'm lost.

The wind howls, bending the
trees. The others drift. Where
should I go? What is left?

Eat a pebble.

...

I opened my eyes. I closed them
again. All is white—the absence
of dark, hard to focus on.

I walked towards it.

The closer I got, the further
away it seemed.

Was I getting bigger?

A crack appeared. Only darkness
poured from it. I walked. Faster.

It turned into a run.
I hit the white.

The white hit me back.

It burst.

...
I vomited.

Someone was knocking.
Have to find another cup.

A tea for two.
Pebble eaters.
Contractions.

EXPANSION

...

It was an island. Thick foliage
but no wildlife. In the middle of
it, on top of a small hill, stood a
giant egg. I had to protect it until
something hatched.

Someone had tried to break it.
The footprints circled its white
structure. Were they mine?

I watched.

I waited.

I waited more.

I watch as you step into my
footprints. We wait together to
break it.

...

The lens lay shattered.
What is left?

...

The silence was too loud.
White noise.

Cracks.
The egg burst.

Rebirth.

...

Waking up was hard. It felt like
lifting lead when I tried to open
my eyes.

I remembered white.
All was dark now.

The Silence.

The wait.

The rebirth.

CONSTRICTION

...

A figure without motion and
no intent. Just a fixed object in
space. Nothing was around it.
Everything narrowed to it.

Passage refused.

Pebbles. Insulting the dark with
white. A clash of white and dark
closing in to crush it.

Flattened.

Expanded.

Silenced.

Remade together without
purpose.

We continue.

...
Even when it started crumbling
I stayed.

Yesterday. This was an echo.

The cups empty.

Pebbles gone.

Collapse.

The winds howled. The trees
swayed in the dusk. The turret
started to disintegrate inwards.

I reach outwards.

The one that lost.
Dissolution.
The burden.

ABSENCE

...

Erase.

Redraw.

A crooked line.

I was. I am. I will be.

An effect to a cause.

A cup. A pebble.

Residue.

I yield.

THE PATH

...

I get up. A path of white cutting
through a moor.

Dusk. My shadow is confused.
The air is thick with salt.

My eyes complain.

My feet start walking.

I feel nothing.